

U.S. students create home in Florence

By Kaya Equevilley



U.S. student at the Florida State University in Florence, Kiara Martin, enters the private campus to meet with her business professor on Wednesday, March 19.

Thousands of American students come to experience life in Florence – one of the most popular abroad destinations in Italy – each semester, but many say it takes a while to navigate the stereotypes that come with being an abroad student and make it home.

There are 140 semester or year U.S. abroad programs across Italy, according to The U.S. Embassy in Italy. And more than a third of those have a program in Florence. This means as many as 15,000 students pass through the region during a year, according to the Association of American College and University Programs in Italy. The local population of the city is about 714,000.

“I notice that this is a stigma against students from the United States. It’s like the locals [students and other residents] put up walls [when it comes] to abroad kids. They assume we fit the stereotypes, and some do,” said Alissa Blevins.

Blevins is in her second year studying at The Florence Institute of Design International for three years. From California, Blevins decided that she wanted to study internationally for her entire college experience.

Blevins said that she feels like locals here see her as an American before anything else.

And that isn't always a compliment, according to students. While the U.S. drinking age is 21, in Italy it's 18 — meaning that, along with adjusting to a new culture, many American college students are also navigating more permissive drinking norms.

“Drunk American students,” is how Debbie Mochi described the American stereotype.

Mochi moved to Florence 12 years ago from Boston. While studying abroad and working to finish her bachelors degree in art history, she fell in love with her now husband and the city, and she decided to make Florence her forever home.

But most students stay for a semester or a year and head back to the United States and locals notice. That makes it hard to become part of the Florence circle, said Jane Farrell, deputy editor at The Florentine, an English news magazine in Florence.

There seems to be a lack of respect from all tourists, not just Americans, said Mochi. However, she said it seemed American students in particular were known to get drunk and loud.

“Imagine that in front of your house every night, it gets old really fast,” Mochi said, “It’s okay to drink, but in Italy they don’t drink to get drunk.”

In Italy, and Europe at large, drinking is woven into daily life and meals, while in the U.S., it's often treated as a rite of passage and tied to binge drinking, especially among college students.

But Mochi said she now sees Italian university students starting to binge drink, influenced by the abroad students. “It’s changing the life of younger Italians,” she said.

“Florence is the perfect size, it is not too big or too small. Nobody treats you like you are out of place, everyone is trying to help us learn,” said Meg Klingerman, a junior from North Carolina.

Klingerman studies at Appalachian State University and is spending three months at Lorenzo de' Medici, The Italian International Institute in Florence.

“I decided to come [on this study abroad] because I had heard a lot of good things about it,” she said. “Plus it’s Italy.”

Klingerman said she had a friend who studied in Florence and that helped influence her decision to come.

The experiences of American students in Florence can vary, but many seem to settle in quickly.

“I experienced culture shock at first but over time I got used to it. Now I feel more like I belong here,” Thomas Deluca, a junior from Long Island, New York, said.

Deluca arrived three months ago and is majoring in sports management. He is studying in Florence through a CIS Abroad program his university, the University of South Carolina, uses. He will stay in Italy for another two months.

“It’s manageable, the people are nice and helpful, the city is walkable, you feel safe, and it’s pretty cheap,” Deluca said.

How long it takes to settle in is a matter of perspective.

“Florence feels like home, but it took a while,” Alyssa Bowen said, “I just feel comfortable, the people make me feel comfortable.”

Bowen is a senior majoring in Art at the University of South Carolina. Bowen is on a three month abroad in Florence through a CIS Abroad program and she arrived one month ago. While she is in Florence she is studying Italian fresco paintings.

A main reason Bowen chose to come to Florence is because the way it would look on her resume. But she said she also wanted to challenge herself.

“I wanted to be pushed to try new things,” Bowen said. “I think that where you come from doesn’t define you, or it shouldn’t be the first assumption.”

Surrounded by an international friend group, Blevins attempts to push against the American stereotype. Blevins said she doesn’t have any American friends in Florence, but only international friends. She said her best friends are German and Polish.

“I stick more to international students in general, because I get judged for being American. I try to surround myself with others to push against the stereotypes, to be less recognizable from where I come from,” Blevins said.

“I like Florence for the most part,” Blevins said.